Chapter 7

Goals of Life

Amidst the roaring waves and bone chilling cold, Abhilash Tommy was not distressed because he had a mission to accomplish. Abhilash Tommy is a retired Indian Navy officer, and he is the first Indian to have completed a solo, non-stop circumnavigation of the world under sail. Have you ever wondered how such adventures are even possible for a human being? According to the conventional way of looking at life, survival is the most important thing. But in the case of Abhilash Tommy, he was not only making a world record, but he was actually proving that the conventional way of looking at life is wrong.

Survival and procreation might be enough for animals and other creatures, but in the case of humans, they owe much more. They can transcend these basic requirements and pursue more meaningful things. The needs of each person are different. Once they have their basic necessities, they will pursue different things. Some of them will try to earn more money, while others are interested in name and fame; some might be more into luxuries; some spend their time studying more things; and some others

do all kinds of crazy stuff. Although people pursue different things in life, there is something in common. If you look carefully you will find that, at the core of all these pursuits are two main goals: enjoyment of pleasure, and avoidance of pain.

The means might be different, but all our endeavours are aimed at getting happiness or avoiding sorrow. This pleasure seeking attitude is driving human behaviour. Indian knowledge systems (IKS) identify this attitude as one of the important goals of human life. It is called 'Kāma'. Kāma means 'desire'. It can be any desire - desire for sensual pleasures, name, or fame, etc.

If you have a kāma, or a desire for something, it immediately creates a feeling of lack in your mind. For instance, if you have a strong desire to watch a new movie, it will automatically create a feeling of uneasiness in your mind, something like a craving. You will get rid of that by watching that movie. To get rid of that uncomfortable feeling, you will try to fulfil that desire.

To fulfil any kāma it is necessary to make an effort. For example, if you have the desire to eat a mango, you have to first pluck it from a mango tree. This is where effort comes in, while fulfilling a desire. You can also buy it from a shop using the money that you have. Even in that case, money is nothing but the result of your previous efforts. This is not just the case of eating a mango or banana; even if you have a kāma to buy a Lamborghini or a Porsche, you need enough money. IKS considers this economic value or effort factor as another aim for human life, and it is called Artha.

Artha is not only money; anything that we consider to be wealth is artha. Health, education, family, friends, power, and position provide access to kāma. In that context, they all can be called artha.

All our pleasures are related to these two aspects, artha and kāma. For a successful life, we need to understand how to properly manage them. All the conflicts we see in the world are nothing

but the result of poor management of artha and kāma. If a person focuses only on fulfilling kāma without paying attention to gaining artha, it is a trap that not only gradually removes their access to any kāma, but also pushes them into extreme pain and distress. We often hear about people who fail to tally their expenses with their income and end up in debt traps. Even if we manage to get some artha, mindful and smart management are required to sustain it. There is another category; people focus just on artha. They just earn more and more money, gold, and other assets. However, in this process, they forget to enjoy their lives.

And there are people who don't care for their health or family, and focus on work instead. This too is mismanagement of artha. While such people may earn money, they lose out on good health, and care of loved ones. What kāma can we enjoy, in poor health, physical or mental? Amma often discusses the case of people who commit suicides in air conditioned homes.

Now we know kāma and artha, but still, something is missing. What will happen if everyone starts pursuing artha and kāma without any checks and balances?

First of all, we don't have that many resources to fulfil everyone's kāma. Needs thus are unlimited, but actual resources are not. It will lead to social turmoil and conflicts. Already, we are short of resources. We humans are using natural resources 1.7 times faster than the earth's biocapacity can regenerate. In other words, we are using the resources of 1.7 Earths! According to the Global Footprint Network's calculation, if everyone in the world is desiring to live like an average American, then we require 5.1 earths to provide those resources.

Activity 2: Visit https://overshoot.footprintnetwork.org/ and look into the "How many Earths would we need if everyone on the planet lived like the residents of your

country?" Study and analyse India's data.

Many of the wars and conflicts have been happening to gain more resources, to fulfil either the ruler's kāma or the citizen's kāma.

Activity 3: List out the wars and conflicts and map it with the Artha-Kama concept

Even if we have enough resources, an immature way of enjoying kāma will not help us get happiness. Only if we fulfil our kāma without harming our body, mind, family, society, or environment, can we achieve happiness and peace. Substance abuse and the consumption of unhealthy foods may give temporary satisfaction, but it will harm our body and eventually destroy not only our Artha, but also the very ability to experience pleasure. Therefore, IKS identifies 'Dharma' as an important aim for human life.

Activity 4: How does fulfilling kāma by harming the body, mind, family, society or environment, eventually destroy artha and denies access to pleasures? Discuss with examples.

Dharma is a non-translatable Sanskrit term. Dharma is often translated as 'righteousness', but dharma has more deep and encompassing aspects than righteousness. IKS describes it as the principle that sustains the entire world and the reason for the complete wellbeing of all the living beings[1]. In the Mahabharata, Maharshi Veda Vyasa emphasises the importance of Dharma in achieving kāma and artha.

"I cry with my arms raised, but nobody listens to me. From Dharma come artha and kāma. Why doesn't anybody heed this?"[2]

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[1] "jagatah sthiti karanam praninam sakshat-abhyudaya-nihshreyasa-hetuh", Bhagavad Gita Bhasya of Sri Sankaracharya.

[2] ūrdhvabāhurviraumyeṣa na ca kaścicchṛṇoti me | dharmādarthaśca kāmaśca sa kimarthaṃ na sevyate || Mahabharata 18.5.49

How long can one acquire artha, and enjoy kama, adharmically (illegally, disrupting the existing system or unsustainably, causing hurt in the process, etc.). Acquiring artha adharmically may seem like easy money, but it's highly risky, and never lasts. Over and above, if one has what it takes to take such risks, why not use it to achieve by fair means? This is exactly what Maharshi's Vyasa expresses in his lamentation.

Dharma also denotes fundamental quality, for example it says heat and light are the Dharmas of fire. Dharma can have the meaning of duty or responsibility. For instance, the Dharma of a king is to protect his citizens.

Similarly each and everyone has their own dharma to play, it is known as 'svadharma'. Svadharma is not only based on one's own responsibilities but also their Guṇas (qualities and aptitude). In the present day scenario, people might do things to gain money. There is no harm in that, but IKS suggests that it should align with one's qualities and aptitudes as well as the collective good.

In short, Indian Knowledge Systems advises us to gain artha and fulfil kāma according to Dharma. Because, it is only through Dharma can we truly gain artha and fulfil our kama. And it is only through Dharma that we truly grow as a person (leading us to the fourth goal).

But still the happiness we are achieving through fulfilling our kāma is momentary. For instance, you had a kāma to buy a brand new phone. You then managed to arrange enough money to buy that phone, and you bought it. You will feel extreme happiness; however, it won't last forever, if it gets damaged, you will lose your happiness, and even if it doesn't, you will also get bored with that phone eventually. As a trough follows a crest in waves, so does sorrow follow happiness. So, to attain eternal happiness and a permanent cessation of sorrow, one has to

transcend their kāma.

The Bhagavata Purana articulates this through the simile of fire and ghee. The purana says: "As supplying butter to a fire does not diminish the fire but instead increases it more and more, the endeavour to stop desires by continual enjoyment can never be successful"[3]. Today, we have enough empirical studies to back this up. First of all, things do not feel the way we anticipate they will [1]. Even if they provide satisfaction, it will not last forever [2].

> **Activity 5:** Share some of your experiences of a fulfilled desire. How did you feel after fulfilling it? Was it the same as your anticipation? How long did that happiness last with the same intensity?

It is in this very pursuit of eternal happiness and a permanent cessation of sorrow, that the great Rishis discovered moksha. Simply put Moksha is permanent liberation from sorrow. According to the Rishis, the real source of happiness is not the objects, but it is within us. Just like a musk deer searching for the cause of the fragrance of the musk, we are in search of happiness. Happiness is not something to achieve; in fact, our real nature is happiness. By realising this, one can permanently be liberated from the cycle of the dualities: happiness and sorrow; punya and papa, life and death. This realisation is the goal of all spiritual practices.

The four aims of life are: Dharma, Artha, Kama, and Moksha. Together, they are called Purusharthas. Dharma is considered the primary Purushartha, since it ensures the sustenance of person and the society. Purusharthas are the blueprint for a successful life. Indian Knowledge Systems advise us to gain Artha and

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[3] na jātu kāmaḥ kāmānām upabhogena śāṁyati | haviṣā kṛṣṇa-vartmeva bhūya evābhivardhate || Srimad Bhagavata Purana 9.19.14

fulfil Kama adhering to Dharma, and also realise mokṣa as the ultimate aim. Though a bird travels miles in search of food, it is not forgetting its nest. In a similar manner, we can try to fulfil our Kāma, gain Artha, according to Dharma. At the same time we should not forget the truth that the happiness we gain from artha-kamas have limitations. The true happiness and permanent redemption from sorrow is only possible through Moksha, that is the realisation of our true nature.

Activity 6: Categorise all of your needs and wants into these four categories, and try to find out if anything does not fall under the framework of Purusharthas.

References

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2. Diener, E., Lucas, R.E., Scollon, C.N. (2009). Beyond the Hedonic Treadmill: Revising the Adaptation Theory of Well-Being . In: Diener, E. (eds) The Science of Well-Being. Social Indicators Research Series, vol 37. Springer, Dordrecht. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-90-481-2350-6_5